

## **Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)**

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# G

## The Gift of Prophecy

As the apostle Peter stated on the day of Pentecost, prophecy was a result of God's Holy Spirit poured out (Acts 2:17-21; see Joel 2:28-32). The book of Acts mentions a few Christian prophets (Acts 11:27-28; 13:1; 15:32; 21:9-11; see also The Martyrdom of Polycarp 12:3; 16:2). One of these prophets was Agabus, who acted like an Old Testament prophet by performing symbolic acts (Acts 21:10-11; see 1 Kings 11:29-32; Isaiah 20:2-6; Jeremiah 13:1-11; Ezekiel 4:1-5:17). He also prophesied future events (Acts 11:28; 21:10-11).

Philip the Evangelist had four daughters "who prophesied" (Acts 21:9). The apostle Paul also recognized that some Christian women had this prophetic gift (1 Corinthians 11:5). In the Old Testament, most prophets were men, but some women were also prophets, like Miriam, Deborah, and Huldah (Exodus 15:20; Judges 4:4; 2 Kings 22:14-20; 2 Chronicles 34:22-28). In the New Testament, both men and women, young and old, receive the gift of prophecy, as Peter mentioned in his sermon on the day of Pentecost (Acts 2:17-18).

Prophecy sometimes involves predicting the future (Acts 20:22-23; 21:10-11; see Romans 9:24-33; 1 Thessalonians 4:13-17; 2 Thessalonians 2:3-4). At its core, prophecy is about sharing God's message by preaching, urging, and explaining God's will (Acts 15:32; 19:6; Romans 12:6; 1 Corinthians 14:3-4, 29-33; Revelation 19:10). The gift of prophecy is plainly mentioned in the letters of 1 Corinthians and Ephesians as one of the gifts of the Holy Spirit and Jesus to his church (1 Corinthians 12:4-11; Ephesians 4:11-13). It is intended to benefit Christians (1 Corinthians 14:22).

Prophecy needs testing (1 Thessalonians 5:19-21). The church receives strong warnings about false prophets (1 John 4:1; see also Revelation 2:20-23). Christians must use this gift faithfully and as the Scriptures and God's Spirit instruct. Boldly sharing God's truth helps the church understand God's will and motivates people to obey it.

### Passages for Further Study

Exodus 15:20; Deuteronomy 13:1-5; Judges 4:4; 1 Kings 11:29-32; 2 Kings 22:14-20; Isaiah 20:2-6; 44:25; Jeremiah 13:1-11; 23:25-32; Ezekiel 4:1-17; 13:2-9; Joel 2:28-32; Matthew 7:15; 24:24; Acts 2:17-21; 11:27-28; 13:1; 15:32; 19:6; 20:23; Acts 21:9-11; Romans 12:6; 1 Corinthians 11:5; 12:4-11; 14:1-40; Ephesians 4:11-13; 1 Thessalonians 5:19-21; 2 Peter 2:1; 1 John 4:1-3; Revelation 2:20-23; 19:10

## Giving up Rights

Paul consistently teaches that Christians should be willing to give up their personal rights and freedoms for the good of others and for the spread of the good news about Jesus. He does not command Christians to defend their rights. Instead, he often urges them not to insist on them, especially within the Christian community (Romans 14:13-23; 1 Corinthians 8:1-13; 10:23-33).

At the same time, Paul recognizes that there are situations in which believers may appropriately use their legal rights. This is especially true in dealings with civil authorities (Acts 16:37-39; 22:25-29; 25:11).

Paul, like Jesus, views loving others as a key principle in life (Romans 13:8-10; 1 Corinthians 13:1-13; Galatians 5:6; see Matthew 5:43-44; 22:36-39). True Christian love is always sacrificial, like Christ's love (1 Corinthians 13:4-7). Christians should focus on what is best for others, not themselves (1 Corinthians 10:32-33). Christ's sacrificial death for sinners shows the nature of true love (Romans 5:6-8; 15:1-5; 1 John 4:9-12). A Christian's life should express Christ's sacrificial love. This is challenging because it requires people to deny their own desires (see Mark 8:34-35).

### Passages for Further Study

Matthew 5:38-48; 16:24-27; 22:37-39; Romans 5:6-8; 13:8-10; 14:15-22; 15:1-5; 1 Corinthians 8:1-13; 9:1-23; 10:23-24, 31-33; 13:4-7; Galatians 5:6; Philippians 2:3-4; 2 Timothy 2:9-13; Hebrews 11:24-26; 1 John 4:9-12

## The Glory of God

Glory in the Old Testament means something different than in English. In English, it often describes something temporary, like a sunset or last year's winning team.

The Hebrew word for glory means what is "heavy" or "solid." It implies "importance" or "worth." This is the opposite of "temporary" or "empty." When God's glory appears, it is not just a bright light or a shining cloud. It is a visible sign of his absolute reality.

God's glory shows his presence, power, and majesty (see Ezekiel 1:28; 10:4). God's glory may appear in nature, like during a thunderstorm or in the plagues on the Egyptians (Job 37:2-5; Psalm 29:3, 7; Numbers 14:21-22). God's glory can also be a special event, like the revelation on Mount Sinai (Deuteronomy 5:24). When God established the tabernacle and King Solomon's temple, God's glory filled them (Exodus 40:34-35; 1 Kings 8:10-11). This showed his approval and presence there. Similarly, the glory of the Lord sent the fire that

started the first sacrifices in the holy place (Leviticus 9:22–24).

When God shows his glory to his creation, it is often called a theophany (see, for example, Exodus 24:16–18). God provides limited views of his glory because he says, “no one can see Me and live” (Exodus 33:18–23; see also Isaiah 6:5). To “give glory” to God means to speak or act in a way that acknowledges who God is (Joshua 7:19; Isaiah 24:15; Jeremiah 13:16).

Jesus Christ reflects God’s glory and image (2 Corinthians 4:4). Through his death and resurrection, God glorified him (John 17:1–5). When Jesus returns, he will show God’s glory in his restored kingdom (Revelation 21:11, 23). The apostle Paul says that Christ’s presence in Christians’ lives guarantees us that we will share in that glory (Romans 5:2; Colossians 1:27).

#### Passages for Further Study

Exodus 14:17–18; 16:6–12; 33:17–23; 40:34–38; Leviticus 9:23–24; 10:1–3; Numbers 14:21–22; Deuteronomy 5:24; Joshua 7:19; 1 Kings 8:11; 2 Chronicles 7:1–3; Job 37:2–5; Psalms 3:3; 8:4–6; 19:1; 29:3, 7–9; 48:8; Isaiah 6:3–5; 42:8; 43:7; 66:18–19; Jeremiah 13:16; Ezekiel 1:28; 10:4; Hosea 4:7; John 17:1–5; Romans 5:2; 2 Corinthians 4:4; Colossians 1:27; Revelation 21:10–11, 23–25

## God as Holy Warrior

The Arabic term jihad, now familiar in English, refers to a “holy war” where men fight for God. Yet, the Bible describes a “holy war” differently. In the Bible, a holy war is a conflict where God fights for his people as they trust in him. In these wars, victory relies on obedience to God, not on weapons.

During a war, King Jehoshaphat of Judah declared a fast and prayed to God with a lament (2 Chronicles 20:3, 5–12). This prayer included calling on God, complaining, confessing trust, and requesting.

Jehoshaphat and the people showed their humility by bowing with their faces to the ground (2 Chronicles 20:18). It is surprising to see an army led by a choir praising God as they march into battle (20:21). Usually battlefields are not for worship and praise. Yet, worship helps people understand God’s will and invites him to save his people. God rewards trust in him. In Jehoshaphat’s case, God defeated a large enemy alliance without Israel needing to fight at all (20:22–24).

The New Testament shows Jesus as the conqueror of all forces against God’s kingdom (see Ephesians 1:19–21). In the end, Jesus will defeat all enemies (1 Corinthians 15:24–28; Revelation 19:11–20:15). This

victory will make God’s rule and worship complete: “Hallelujah! For the Lord our God the Almighty reigns” (Revelation 19:6).

#### Passages for Further Study

Joshua 6:1–20; 10:7–15; Judges 7:7–22; 2 Kings 19:14–37; 2 Chronicles 6:34–35; 20:5–7, 20–24; Isaiah 26:21–27:6; Jonah 3:4–10; Matthew 16:18; 2 Corinthians 10:3–6; Ephesians 1:19–23; 6:10–20; Revelation 19:11–21

## God or Satan?

Who is responsible for trials and difficulties? It might seem strange, but Scripture sometimes says God, sometimes Satan, and sometimes both. How is this possible? Understanding this requires looking at these situations from different points of view.

The Bible tells the story of King David’s census in two different books, and they describe what happened in different ways. Second Samuel 24:1 says God “stirred up David against them” by taking a census. In contrast, 1 Chronicles 21:1 says “Satan rose up against Israel and incited David to take a census of Israel.” Second Samuel 24:1–25 tells the census story from God’s perspective. God allowed Satan’s actions to achieve his purpose.

This is common in Scripture. Matthew 4:1 says the Holy Spirit led Jesus into the wilderness where Satan would test him. This shows how God and Satan can both be involved in the same event but with different purposes.

A notable example is Job’s suffering. God had praised Job for being a faithful person. Then he gave Satan permission to cause Job great suffering (Job 1:6–2:7). Despite the difficulties, Job remained righteous. He resisted Satan’s attempts to make him curse God.

Similarly, 2 Corinthians 12:7 teaches that God can send an affliction through a messenger from Satan. When Paul mentioned his “thorn,” he used a passive verb, showing that God gave this “torment.” The way Paul describes this shows that God allowed this trouble to happen, even though it came through a messenger from Satan.

Satan tries many different ways to hurt and discourage people who follow God. But God is in control of everything. God does not create evil but sometimes he uses the evil actions of others to accomplish his good purposes (Genesis 50:20).

#### Passages for Further Study

2 Samuel 24:1–25; 1 Chronicles 21:1–30; Job 1:8–2:10; Matthew 4:1–11; 12:22–37; Mark 8:31–33; John 13:21–31;

Romans 8:28; 1 Corinthians 5:1-5; 2 Corinthians 12:6-10; Ephesians 2:1-7; Revelation 20:1-3, 7-10

## God Protects His Servant

When God called the prophet Jeremiah as his messenger, he promised to protect him. This protection was spiritual, as the Lord gave Jeremiah inner strength “like a fortified city” (Jeremiah 1:18). God’s protection was also physical: “They will fight against you but will never overcome you” (1:19).

During King Josiah’s rule (from 640 to 609 BC), Jeremiah was safe and did not experience serious threats to his life. Things changed when Jehoiakim became king (from 609 to 598 BC). The king and his officials quickly became hostile, putting Jeremiah’s life at risk. But the Lord promised to protect him (see Jeremiah 11:18-23).

This promise seemed broken when Pashhur arrested, whipped, and put Jeremiah in stocks (Jeremiah 20:1-2). Jeremiah questioned the Lord for misleading him. But soon he regained his trust (20:7-13). Early in Jehoiakim’s rule, he arrested Jeremiah and put him on trial (chapter 26). The Lord strengthened Jeremiah internally, helping him stay calm.

Some elders who served under King Josiah protected him. They reminded others of King Hezekiah’s response to danger a century earlier. Ahikam saved Jeremiah’s life (Jeremiah 26:24). Jeremiah went into hiding when Jehoiakim’s officers tried to kill him. The Lord kept him hidden until after Jehoiakim’s death (36:19-20, 26).

The new king, Zedekiah, treated Jeremiah more kindly. Yet, Jeremiah encountered danger several times during the attack against Jerusalem. At one point, the king’s officials threw him into a muddy well (cistern). God protected Jeremiah by inspiring a foreigner named Ebed-melech, to save him. Zedekiah then put Jeremiah in protective custody (Jeremiah 38).

Jeremiah survived when the Babylonians captured Jerusalem. Although he was almost taken captive to Babylon. God influenced the Babylonian general to free Jeremiah. He offered him a choice. He could go to Babylon as a free man or stay with Gedaliah, the new governor of Judah (Jeremiah 39:11-14; 40:1-6). God also protected Jeremiah from Johanan and his group, who forced Jeremiah and Baruch to go to Egypt (43:1-7).

God kept his promises to Jeremiah. He continues to keep his promises to all his people. He does not always promise to physically protect those who serve him (see 2 Corinthians 6:4-5; 2 Timothy 2:10-13; 3:11-13; 1 Peter 2:21-23; 3:14-17; Revelation 14:12). But he

promises eternal salvation to those who trust in him (James 1:12; 1 Peter 1:6-9; 4:12-19).

## Passages for Further Study

Genesis 20:3-7; 31:24; Numbers 14:10-35; 2 Kings 6:14-20; Job 1:9-11; Psalm 91:1-16; Jeremiah 1:18-19; 11:18-23; 20:1-2, 7-13; 26:24; 36:19-20, 26; 39:11-14; Matthew 2:13-22; 10:28-31; John 15:20; Acts 12:1-11; 2 Corinthians 6:4-5; 2 Timothy 2:10-13; 3:11-13; Hebrews 11:4-37; James 1:12; 1 Peter 1:6; 3:14-17; 4:12-19; Revelation 14:12

## God Works through Prayer

God has authority and control over all creation. But he wants people to share their concerns with him through prayer. The Bible shows examples of God responding to people’s prayers. Prayer is important for living a godly life and effective Christian service. It helps people submit their will to God.

The short book of Nehemiah tells the story of a man devoted to prayer. When he saw Jerusalem’s poor condition, Nehemiah prayed intensely for four months (see Nehemiah 1:1; 2:1). His prayers praised God for his power and love. Nehemiah confessed the nation’s sins and asked God to help (1:4-11; see also Ezra 9:6-15; Daniel 9:4-19). Nehemiah’s based his prayer for Jerusalem on God’s “covenant of loving devotion with those who love Him and keep His commandments” (1:5).

The Israelites had not followed the instructions God gave to Moses (1:7). As God had warned, this disobedience resulted in their exile. Yet, Nehemiah firmly believed that God would restore the nation if the people repented (1:8-9; see Deuteronomy 4:25-31; 30:1-5).

God gave Nehemiah a chance to speak to the Persian king about returning to Jerusalem. Nehemiah prayed for guidance (Nehemiah 2:4). He understood that only God could change the king’s will. Later, Nehemiah responded to threats against the builders of Jerusalem’s wall by posting guards and encouraging the people. Yet, he also prayed for protection and strength (Nehemiah 4:4-5, 9; 6:9, 14). He needed God’s help and blessing both then and in the future as he dealt with those who behaved wrongly.

Nehemiah returned to Jerusalem after a short visit to Persia. He learned that some Jews were not giving their tithe (Nehemiah 13:10-12). Some were not observing the Sabbath (13:15-16). Some had married non-Jews (13:23-24). When he confronted them about their actions, Nehemiah prayed for God to show him compassion and remember his efforts (13:14, 22, 31).

Nehemiah understood that only God's power could change people.

Jesus knew well the Father's will, yet his ministry had its basis in prayer (see, for example, Luke 5:16; 6:12-16; 9:18). Following his example, early Christians prayed often, believing firmly in its power (see, for example, 9:36-41; 12:3-11). God often responds powerfully to prayers. God wants Christians to pray with confidence, expecting him to answer (see James 5:16-18).

#### Passages for Further Study

Genesis 24:10-20; Judges 15:18-20; Ezra 9:6-15; Nehemiah 1:4-11; 2:4-5; 4:4-5, 9; Psalms 18:1-30; 22:4-5, 24; 30:2-3; 31:22; 34:4; 40:1-2; 81:7; 106:1-48; 107:6-7, 13-14; 116:1; 118:5; Daniel 9:4-19; Jonah 2:1-10; Acts 4:24-31; James 5:16-18

### God's Absolute Holiness

Holiness is one main way to describe God. It is not just one of his many traits, it is central to who he is. Calling God "the Holy One" emphasizes how he is completely different than anyone or anything else. Creation exists within the limits of time, but nothing limits God.

God calls himself, "I AM WHO I AM" (Exodus 3:14). This means he defines himself by himself. God is entirely different, completely self-sufficient, and separate from what he created.

God's holiness also refers to his character. People often describe God's holiness as his separation from sin and his anger against it. Yet, holiness includes all aspects of God's character, such as his mercy. God revealed himself to Moses as the "God of compassion and mercy." He is, "slow to anger, abounding in loving devotion and faithfulness, maintaining loving devotion to a thousand generations, forgiving iniquity, transgression, and sin. Yet He will by no means leave the guilty unpunished" (Exodus 34:6-7).

God's holiness can be dangerous to those who approach without permission and respect (Isaiah 6:3, 5; see Exodus 28:35). His endless holiness is overwhelming for imperfect humans. It would completely destroy them without God's mercy.

When we understand God's holiness, it should fill us with deep respect and wonder. We must not treat God's holiness casually or without proper honor. This might have been the mistake that led to Nadab and Abihu's deaths (Leviticus 10:1-3). Only by recognizing the awesomeness of God can we truly appreciate his love for us and worship him rightly and sincerely.

#### Passages for Further Study

Exodus 3:14; 34:6-7; Leviticus 10:3; Leviticus 11:44-45; 1 Samuel 2:1-2; Isaiah 6:3-5; 52:10; Hosea 11:9

### God's Anger

God is just and righteous in his judgment (Psalm 7:11). He responds with righteous anger toward sin and injustice. God's anger is not like human anger. It is not an emotional outburst or loss of control. It is his perfect, holy response to evil. Wicked people persist in doing wrong and deserve his judgment (see 2:5, 12; 21:9; 56:7; 59:13; 69:24; 79:6; see also Romans 1:18). Even though God is patient and slow to become angry, he will not allow evil to continue forever without stopping it (86:15; 103:8; 145:8).

The writers of the psalms saw Israel's escape from Egypt as a lesson about God's anger. God showed his anger against the Egyptians while protecting his people (Psalm 78:49-50). But during their journey through the wilderness, Israel's disobedience led to God's anger, and they faced his judgment (78:31; 106:29, 32).

Because of this, God promised that disobedient generation would not enter his place of rest (Psalm 95:8-11). So they died in the wilderness. But God held back his anger and did not destroy Israel completely (78:38).

In the same way, throughout the time of the judges and kings, God's people often disobeyed and did evil things. As a result, in his anger, God allowed foreign powers to control them and send them into exile (2 Kings 17:5-23; 24:20-25:21). But again, God did not allow his people to be completely destroyed.

When God's people sin and feel his anger, it can lead them to repent. This emotionally painful experience can bring great joy in God's mercy and goodness (Psalm 30:5; see also Hebrews 12:5-11).

The New Testament makes clear that all people were subject to God's wrath because of sin (Ephesians 2:1-3). But in his love, God sent his Son, Jesus Christ, who gave his life for our sins so that we could be reconciled to God (Romans 5:6-11; Ephesians 2:4-5). Those who turn to God in faith will escape the punishment that is coming at the future judgment of the world. In the end, Jesus, who is both Savior and Judge, will bring God's justice against the wicked (Psalms 2:5-9; Revelation 6:15-17; 19:11-16). God will deal decisively with all evil, including his ultimate enemy, the devil (Revelation 20:7-15).

#### Passages for Further Study

Psalms 2:5-9, 12; 6:1; 7:6, 11-13; 21:9; 27:9; 30:5; 38:1-10; 74:1; 78:18-64; 79:5-6; 80:4; 85:2-7; 86:15; 90:9-11; 95:8-11; 102:10-11; 103:8-9; 106:21-43; 110:5-7; 145:8;

Isaiah 64:9–12; Lamentations 5:19–22; Romans 2:5–11; Ephesians 5:6; Revelation 6:15–17; 11:18; 19:11–16

## God's Change of Mind

The Old Testament describes God 34 times as “changing his mind” or “being sorry” (the Hebrew word *nakham*). What does this mean? Does God relent, feel pity, experience sorrow, or grieve?

One thing is clear: God never repents of sin or moral failure because he is perfect (see 1 Samuel 15:29; Numbers 23:19). God may “change his mind” about disaster or judgment that he started. This means God may decide to change his plans in response to:

- when people pray with repentance (Jeremiah 18:7–10; Joel 2:14; Jonah 3:9–10);
- when a human speaks to God on behalf of others (Exodus 32:11–14; Amos 7:2–6); or
- without any clear human involvement (Judges 2:18; 2 Samuel 24:16).

A few times, God regrets something he has already done. For example, God regretted choosing Saul as king (1 Samuel 15:11, 35; compare Genesis 6:6). But God is not admitting he made mistakes in the past. He is showing sadness about lives that have gone wrong.

Theologians debate how much God, who is all-wise and all-powerful, can “change his mind.” In the Bible, when it seems like God changes his mind, it shows a human view of God's actions. Any change that God seems to show is how humans experience God. God is constant in his love, mercy, faithfulness, and holy will. God's power, all-knowing nature, foreknowledge, wisdom, and holiness do not change.

### Passages for Further Study

Genesis 6:6–7; Exodus 32:11–14; Numbers 23:19; Deuteronomy 32:36; 1 Samuel 15:10–11, 29, 35; 2 Samuel 24:15–16; Jeremiah 4:28; 18:7–10; 26:2–19; Ezekiel 24:14; Joel 2:13–14; Amos 7:2–6; Jonah 3:9–4:11

## God's Commitment to His People

Sometimes, God's people have had to wait what seems like a long time to see God's promises come true. Here are some examples from the Bible:

- God first promised Abraham and Sarah he would make them a great nation. Yet, they had to wait twenty-five years from the time God first promised to make them a great nation until their son Isaac was born.
- God promised David the kingship. Yet, David encountered many challenges during King Saul's rule before God finally made him king.

- God promised to bring a remnant of people back to the promised land after the exile to Babylon. Yet, the Jewish captives waited seventy years to return. But, in each case, God fulfilled his promises.
- Zechariah prophesied while the people rebuilt the temple after the exile. During the reconstruction, God told Zechariah not to despise “the day of small things” (Zechariah 4:10). God had acted in the past for the ultimate good of his people, even during the exile to Babylon (see 7:12–14). God would achieve his plans for Israel's well-being in his own time and way. The people of Israel could find courage in the present and hope for the future. This was because God keeps his word and fulfills his promises (4:9).

God wants patience and faith from his people, not loud demands. He kept his promises by guaranteeing his people would return to Jerusalem and rebuild the temple.

About five hundred years after Zechariah, God fulfilled his promise of bringing salvation to all nations by sending Jesus the Messiah. Similarly, we can trust Jesus' promise that he will return to fully establish his kingdom (see Matthew 24:27, 30; see also Acts 1:6–11).

### Passages for Further Study

1 Samuel 15:29; 2 Samuel 7:28–29; 2 Chronicles 36:21; Isaiah 42:1–9; 49:15; Zechariah 2:13; 4:9–10; 14:3; John 14:1–4; 17:17; Acts 1:6–11; Titus 1:2; Revelation 21:5

## God's Covenant Love

The Bible talks about God's love in two main ways. First, there is the common understanding that God deeply cares about and has great affection for all people. Second, in some parts of the Bible, like Deuteronomy (where God makes special agreements with his people), God's love means his faithful promise to stay with his people and take care of them.

In the ancient Near East, a conquering king often described his relationship with conquered peoples (vassals) with terms of love. This meant he chose them to enjoy his favor and protection in exchange for their loyalty.

In a similar way, God chose Israel to be his servant nation. This was not because they deserved it, but because he chose to love them (Deuteronomy 7:6–11). In other words, he loved them because he had chosen them. The strongest example of this is in Malachi 1:2–3. God chose Jacob but rejected Esau (see also Romans 9:13–26).

God extended the special covenant relationship with Israel to include both Jews and non-Jews (gentiles)

through Jesus Christ (Acts 10:1-11:18; Ephesians 2:11-22). God established this new covenant through the ultimate demonstration of his love in the suffering and death of his son Jesus (Luke 22:20; John 3:16).

#### Passages for Further Study

Deuteronomy 7:6-11; 33:3; Isaiah 49:14-18; Hosea 11:1-11; Malachi 1:2-3; Matthew 3:16-17; Luke 15:1-32; John 3:16; 16:25-27; Romans 5:6-8; 9:13-26; Ephesians 1:4; 2:4-7; Hebrews 12:6-11; 1 John 3:1; 4:8-9, 16

### God's Covenant with Abraham

God started a relationship with Abraham before making a formal covenant (binding agreement) with him (Genesis 12:1-9; 15). God started the relationship with Abraham by speaking to him in a vision. God promised that the elderly Abraham would have a son. He said that he would have as many descendants as there are stars in the sky. Abraham trusted God (15:6). God considered Abraham's faith to be an act of righteousness (see Habakkuk 2:4; Romans 1:17; 4:3, 17; Galatians 3:6, 11; Hebrews 10:37-38).

In the ancient Near East, kings sometimes gave land or other gifts to loyal subjects. The covenant of Genesis 15 includes a royal gift (15:18-21). God, the king, gave land to Abraham, his subject, to possess and inherit it. By the end of that day, Abraham knew that his future and the future of his descendants was secure. His covenant God would take care of him. Later, the land would belong to his descendants.

God later confirmed his covenant with Abraham (Genesis 17:1-22). He gave circumcision as its sign (17:10) and requirement (17:9).

The covenant was not between equals, but both sides had duties. God willingly committed to Abraham and his descendants, while expecting Abraham's faithfulness (17:1, 9-14). The new name God gave him showed the blessing Abraham received as God's partner (17:5-6).

God's covenant with Abraham also included his descendants (Genesis 13:15-16; 15:3-5; 17:6-10). It promised blessings soon to come when his descendants would own the land (15:12-16).

Much later, Abraham's faith blessed everyone through his descendant, Jesus Christ. Through Jesus, all families on earth can share in God's blessing to Abraham (12:3; see Romans 4:11-25; Galatians 3:8-9, 16).

#### Passages for Further Study

Genesis 12:1-3; 15:1-21; 17:1-14; 21:1-2; 22:15-18; Exodus 2:24; Deuteronomy 1:8; Nehemiah 9:7-8; Psalm 105:7-

45; Luke 3:7-9; Acts 3:24-26; 7:2-8; Romans 4:11-25; 9:7-8; 11:16-17; Galatians 3:6-9, 29; Hebrews 6:13-15

### God's Covenant with David

God made five special agreements (called covenants) with his people in the Old Testament:

1. God promised Noah, his family, and the creation that a flood would never again destroy the world (Genesis 6:18; 9:1-17). This is called the Noachian covenant.
2. God promised Abraham the land of Canaan and that he would become a great nation (Genesis 15:1-21; 17:1-27). This is called the Abrahamic covenant.
3. God began a special relationship with Israel at Mount Sinai through Moses (Exodus 19-23). This is called the Mosaic covenant.
4. God promised Aaron's grandson Phinehas that his descendants would be priests (Numbers 25:10-13). This is called the Priestly covenant.
5. God promised David that he and his descendants would be kings (2 Samuel 7:4-17). This is called the Davidic covenant.

God also promised through Jeremiah to make a future "new covenant" (Jeremiah 31:31-34).

In 2 Samuel 7, God's promise to David is not called a covenant. But other passages do call it a covenant (see 23:5; 2 Chronicles 7:18; 21:7; Psalms 89:3-4, 28-29; 132:11-12; Isaiah 55:3; Jeremiah 33:20-21). God's promise to David that his "loving devotion will never be removed" suggests a covenant relationship (2 Samuel 7:15). Like God's promise to Abraham, his covenant with David is unconditional. It ultimately relies on God's unchanging love, not on human obedience or faithfulness.

The most important part of God's covenant with David is God's promise to always continue David's descendants and to be like a father to them (compare 1 Kings 11:36; 15:4; 2 Kings 8:19). God's blessing on David's son Solomon partly fulfills this promise (compare 2 Samuel 7:10-11 with 1 Kings 8:56; see also 1 Kings 8:20, 24). God was patient with the kings of Judah, even when they did evil things. This was because of his promise to David (see 1 Kings 11:12-13; 15:3-5).

The complete fulfillment of God's promise to David is in the Messiah, Jesus Christ, the "Son of David" (see Matthew 9:27; 20:30-31; 21:9, 15). Isaiah prophesied that someone who would "reign from the throne of David and over his kingdom ... forevermore" (Isaiah 9:7). He called him the "shoot" growing "from the stump of Jesse" (Isaiah 11:1). These references point to the coming Messiah (God's chosen one).

Four passages in the New Testament show that Jesus fulfills the promises made to David by directly referring to 2 Samuel 7:1–29 (Luke 1:32–33; Acts 2:29–31; 13:22–23; Hebrews 1:5). The New Testament begins and ends by calling Jesus “the son of David,” the heir to his throne (Matthew 1:1; Revelation 22:16).

#### Passages for Further Study

2 Samuel 7:5–16; 1 Kings 8:20–24; 11:9–13; 15:1–5; 2 Kings 8:18–19; 2 Chronicles 7:17–22; Psalms 89:3–4, 18–51; 132:10–12; Isaiah 9:6–7; 11:1–10; Jeremiah 33:20–26; Matthew 1:1; 20:30–31; 21:1–9; Luke 1:30–33, 67–79; Acts 2:22–36; Revelation 22:16

### God's Covenant with Israel's Kings

Solomon understood his role as David's successor (1 Kings 3:7). The elderly King David advised Solomon to follow all of God's laws from Moses to “prosper in all you do and wherever you turn” (2:3). Solomon's faithfulness would fulfill God's promises to David (1 Kings 2:4; see 2 Samuel 7:5–16). Early in his rule, he intentionally showed his father's love and faithfulness to God (1 Kings 3:3). He saw that God had kept his promises to David (8:23–26).

Several times during Solomon's rule, God communicated the permanent nature of his covenant (special agreement) with David (1 Kings 3:14; 9:4–5; 11:38). God judged Solomon and later kings based on their faithfulness to that covenant compared to David (11:12–13; 14:8; 15:3–5, 11). God's approval and blessings or disapproval and judgment depended on whether people obeyed or violated his law (see Deuteronomy 28).

During the time of the kings, God condemned the people of Israel for intentionally rejecting the Lord's written rules in the law and those spoken by God's prophets (2 Kings 17:13–17). Their rejection of God led to judgment (2 Kings 17:18–23; 21:11–15).

How God dealt with the kings of Israel serves as an example for those in a covenant with God through Jesus. Today, God's people must love Jesus and follow his commandments (John 14:21). They must remain faithful in all things (Matthew 25:21; Luke 16:10–12; 2 Timothy 3:14; 4:7). Those who follow David's example of faithfulness will receive God's praise (see Acts 13:22). Those who confess the name of Jesus, David's heir, and are devoted to God and his word will try to live pure and pleasing lives for God (Acts 13:32–37; Hebrews 13:20–21). They know they will receive many good gifts from God that will last forever (2 Timothy 4:8; Revelation 2:10; compare Galatians 5:19–21).

#### Passages for Further Study

2 Samuel 7:5–17; 1 Kings 2:2–4; 3:3–15; 8:22–26; 9:1–9; 11:1–13, 29–39; 14:7–16; 15:1–5, 11; 2 Kings 17:13–23; 21:11–15; Acts 13:21–23

### God's Covenant with Noah

A covenant is a special agreement or promise between two groups or individuals. In the Bible, covenants are often made between God and humans. These agreements typically include promises, obligations, and sometimes signs or symbols to remember the covenant. The first clear mention of a covenant in Scripture appears right after the great flood (Genesis 9:1–17).

God saw that humans had become very wicked and were doing evil things. This grieved God, and God regretted making humans on the earth (Genesis 6:5–7). God punished humans because of their corruption and violence (Genesis 6:11–13). But God still showed kindness to Noah (6:8). God told Noah to build an ark (a large boat) to survive the coming flood (6:13–17). Although humanity was unfaithful, God promised to make a covenant with Noah, his family, and all creation (6:1–7; 9:8–13).

God guaranteed a relationship with Noah's family, even as other relationships between God and humans ended (Genesis 6:18). God's promise to Noah included the command to build an ark (6:14). For Noah to receive the blessing from the covenant, he had to obey this command (6:22; 7:5).

After the great flood, Noah made an offering to God (Genesis 8:20–22). God then explained his covenant with Noah. This covenant was universal, including humans and all living creatures (9:8–10). God promised never to send another flood as a judgment on the world (9:15).

This covenant helps us understand what God's covenants mean. Even though people deserve punishment for their wickedness, God withholds complete destruction. God's covenant with Noah did not establish a close relationship between God and every living being. Instead, it remade moral and earthly life as God intended (Genesis 9:1–7). This allowed for a more intimate covenant in the future (17:1–21). Although they do what is wrong, people can live in God's world and seek a deeper relationship with the Creator during their lives. God's later covenants made a close relationship with him available to everyone (Acts 2:22–40; 3:17–26).

#### Passages for Further Study

Genesis 9:1–17; Ezekiel 14:12–23; Matthew 24:37–39; Hebrews 11:7

## God's Covenants

The word “covenant” (from the Hebrew word *berith*) means “bond.” A covenant is a binding relationship based on a commitment that includes promises and duties. The covenant relationship requires faithfulness and enables peace and harmony.

Covenants can be between:

- individuals (for example, Genesis 21:27)
- entire nations (for example, Joshua 9:15–18)
- God and humans

The covenant theme in the Old Testament starts with the patriarch Noah. Through Noah, God made a promise to all creation. God promised he would keep taking care of the world he created. He gave the rainbow as a sign to show he would keep this promise (Genesis 9:1–17).

God later made a covenant with the patriarch Abraham and his family. The sign of this covenant was circumcision (Genesis 12:1–9; 15:1–21; 17:9–14). (Circumcision is the process of removing the foreskin of the male reproductive organ.) God's covenant with Abraham promised descendants, land, rulers, and blessings for all nations. These promises became the basis for future covenants God made with his people.

God's covenant with the people of Israel at Mount Sinai was a national agreement. The sign of this covenant was the Sabbath day, a weekly day of rest (Exodus 19–24). It explained how Israel would be God's chosen people. This covenant was like a suzerain-vassal treaty. This was an ancient agreement between a powerful king (called a suzerain) and loyal subjects (called a vassal; see study note on Exodus 20:1–23:33).

God renewed the covenant at Mount Sinai in the book of Deuteronomy and in Joshua 24:1–28. The renewed covenant emphasized God's promise of land and how Israel should behave while living there. Through this covenant, God confirmed that he was their God and they were his people. This meant he required their complete loyalty (Jeremiah 11:4; 24:7; Ezekiel 11:20; 14:11). God, as the great king (the suzerain), would bless and protect the nation of Israel (the vassal). Israel's duty was to be loyal to God's commands, decrees, and regulations (Exodus 19:5, 8; 24:3, 7; Deuteronomy 30:15–20).

God later made a covenant with King David (2 Samuel 7:5–16). This covenant related to the family line of kings promised to Abraham and Jacob (Genesis 17:6, 16; 35:11).

Years later, during a difficult time in Israel's history, the prophet Jeremiah spoke of a “new covenant” for

Israel in the future (Jeremiah 31:31–33). This covenant would finally fulfill the promises of the covenants with Abraham and Israel. Jeremiah's prophecy came true through the life and work of Jesus Christ (see Luke 22:20; Hebrews 8:6–13; 12:24). This new covenant fully realized the earlier promises made to God's people.

God made these covenants because of his faithful love (from the Hebrew word *khesed*). This love made it possible for God and his people to keep having a close relationship with each other. God started this relationship, set its terms, and rewarded his people if they obeyed. These covenants were divine gifts, not rewards. God might exclude people from the covenant (see Hosea 1:9). But he will not violate or cancel his covenants.

If humans failed to keep their part of the covenant or rejected it completely, God's faithful love is the only thing that can renew it (Exodus 34:6–9; Jeremiah 31:31–33). While God's love maintains the relationship, his people must not mock his grace (Isaiah 54:7–10; 55:3; 61:8; 1 Corinthians 6:9–10; Galatians 6:7).

### Passages for Further Study

Genesis 9:1–17; 12:1–9; 15:1–21; 17:9–14; Exodus 6:2–5; 19:1–24:18; Leviticus 26:1–46; Deuteronomy 7:7–15; 29:2–29; Joshua 8:30–35; 24:1–8; 2 Samuel 7:5–16; Ezra 10:1–17; Isaiah 59:20–21; Jeremiah 31:31–34; 33:19–26; 34:12–20; Ezekiel 16:1–63; Luke 22:20; Galatians 4:21–31; Ephesians 2:11–13; Hebrews 8:6–13; 10:11–18; 12:24

## God's Faithfulness to His People

God made a special agreement (called a covenant) with the people of Israel. It included blessings for obedience and curses for disobedience (see Deuteronomy 28:1–68). Many years later, after King Solomon dedicated the temple, the Lord appeared to him. He reminded Solomon that if the people were unfaithful to this covenant, judgment would come (1 Kings 9:6–9). But, if they were faithful, God would live among them and never abandon them (6:12–13).

God chose the nation of Israel as his covenant people (Exodus 19:5–6; 1 Kings 8:53). Despite this special role, the people of Israel often rebelled against God (see, for example, Exodus 32:1–6; Numbers 14:1–12; Judges 2:10–15). Even during the peak of God's blessings under Solomon's rule, they “were still sacrificing on the high places” (3:2). They showed their ongoing commitment to pagan worship (see also 1 Kings 11:4–13).

Both the northern and southern kingdoms later committed this sin (12:31–32; 13:2, 32–33; 14:22–24; 15:14; 22:43). Every ruler of the northern kingdom led the people into false religious practices. This caused

Israel's exile by Assyria in 722 BC. The southern kingdom had occasional religious reforms. But these were temporary, and Judah was eventually exiled by the Babylonians in 586 BC.

Yet, God kept a faithful group among his people (see, for example, 1 Kings 19:18; Isaiah 10:20–34). He had plans for their future well-being (see Isaiah 4:2–6; Isaiah 40:1–11; Jeremiah 30:1–24). Despite their unfaithfulness, God remained loving and faithful and wanted to restore them (Hosea 2:1–23).

God still has a group of people who belong to him (1 Corinthians 1:2; 1 Peter 1:1). Those who follow Jesus are his “chosen people” (1 Peter 2:9–10). They are “the temple of the living God” (2 Corinthians 6:14–7:1). God promises that he will never abandon them. He will always keep his promises to them (John 14:16; 2 Timothy 2:13).

#### Passages for Further Study

Genesis 32:10; Exodus 3:13–17; 34:6; Deuteronomy 7:9; 31:6; Joshua 1:5; 21:45; 2 Samuel 7:16; 1 Kings 6:12–13; 8:29–53; 9:3–9; Psalms 31:1–5; 91:4; Isaiah 40:1–11; 54:8; Lamentations 3:22–24; Micah 7:18–20; John 14:16; Romans 3:3–4; 11:25–29; 1 Corinthians 10:13; 2 Corinthians 1:20; 2 Timothy 2:13; Titus 1:2; Hebrews 10:23; 11:11; 1 Peter 4:19; Revelation 1:4–5; 19:11

### God's Glory with His People

In ancient Israel, God's glory was especially visible at the main holy places built for him. When the Israelites finished building the Tent of Meeting, “the glory of the Lord filled the tabernacle” (Exodus 40:34–35). In a similar way, after they completed the temple and brought in the ark of the covenant, “the glory of the LORD filled the house of the LORD” (1 Kings 8:10–11).

The presence and absence of God's glory is a key theme in the book of Ezekiel. God's glory appears to the prophet Ezekiel while he is in exile in Babylon. This means God's glory was no longer at the temple in Jerusalem. Ezekiel's vision in Ezekiel 8–11 explains why God's glory left the temple. The prophet sees the terrible acts that had spiritually polluted the temple. Without God's presence, the temple became an empty framework, waiting for destruction.

God did not leave the temple because the Babylonian army forced him out. He left because of his people's spiritual pollution. Their sin made him leave the land promised to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. For a time, the Lord moved from Jerusalem to Babylon to be a holy place for the exiles there (see 11:16).

God would not leave his temple forever. After fully punishing the people, he would bring a small group back to their land and make them holy by his Spirit. This would allow him to live among them in a new holy place (Ezekiel 37:26). The idea of God's glory living among his people forever is central to Ezekiel's vision of their restoration (43:1–5).

The glory of God lives among his people fully through Jesus Christ. The apostle John says, “We have seen His glory, the glory of the one and only Son from the Father” (John 1:14). The elderly Simeon saw baby Jesus in the temple and called him “a light for revelation to the Gentiles, and for glory to Your people Israel” (Luke 2:32). While Jesus lived on earth, his glory was hidden from view. However, something special happened on a mountain called the Mount of Transfiguration. There, for a brief time, Jesus let his closest disciples see his true heavenly brightness and glory (Matthew 17:2).

When dying on the cross, Jesus carried the curse for our sins. In his human nature, Jesus felt abandoned by God (Matthew 27:46). But now, Jesus has been given the highest honor and power. God has given him the most important place next to himself, “seated... at His right hand” (Ephesians 1:19–20). Through the Holy Spirit, he promises to remain with us until the end of time (Matthew 28:20).

#### Passages for Further Study

Exodus 15:11; 33:18–34:8; 40:34; Psalm 19:1–11; Isaiah 4:5–6; 6:3; 40:5; 42:8; 43:7; 58:8; 60:1–2; Ezekiel 1:1–28; 11:16; 37:26; 43:1–5; 44:4; Habakkuk 2:14; Matthew 17:2; 28:20; Luke 2:32; John 1:14; 2 Corinthians 4:4–6; Hebrews 1:3; Revelation 21:10–11, 23

### God's Grief over Apostasy

The God of the universe feels sorrow when his people suffer (Judges 10:16; Hosea 11:8–9). Even when people reject him, God's love is stronger than his justice. His compassion is greater than his judgment. Yet, this does not mean his love cancels his justice. People will face judgment for their choices and actions in the end (see 2 Timothy 4:1; Revelation 20:11–15).

The era of the Israelite judges shows how God responds when his people repeatedly reject him. There comes a time, like when Noah lived, when God no longer exercises patience (Genesis 6:5–7). For the Israelites living at the time of the judges, that moment had arrived.

After they worshiped other gods, God let their enemies oppress them. He told them, “Go and cry out to the gods you have chosen. Let them save you in your time of trouble” (Judges 10:14). Yet, when Israel asked for

mercy again, removed their idols, and accepted the Lord's justice, God helped them (10:10, 15-16).

God wants people to repent because he does not want to destroy anyone (2 Peter 3:9). He does this "to justify the one who has faith in Jesus" (Romans 3:26). "He bore the sin of many" and offers us the chance to receive his grace (see Isaiah 53:3-12; 2 Corinthians 5:19-21).

#### Passages for Further Study

Genesis 6:5-7; Judges 10:6-16; Isaiah 5:1-7; 53:3-12; 63:10; Hosea 11:8-9; Ephesians 4:30

### God's Inscrutable Purposes in History

God directs people and events to achieve his purposes in history. He does not need to explain himself, but he always has a purpose. He guides individuals, nations, and events to achieve his will. This view of history stays consistent throughout biblical history. God uses human actions to achieve results that only his planning can explain.

The writer of the book of Chronicles explains the division of Israel's kingdom in a simple way. Rehoboam and his followers "listened to the words of the LORD and turned back from going against Jeroboam" (2 Chronicles 11:4). The reason for the division was Rehoboam's unreasonable response to the people's request. This was already explained earlier: "This turn of events was from God, in order that the LORD might fulfill the word that He had spoken through Ahijah the Shilonite to Jeroboam son of Nebat" (10:15). Rehoboam might have easily defeated the rebels, but the Lord's will stopped him.

Obedying God's will brought positive results for Rehoboam. He strengthened cities, appointed military leaders, and stocked equipment and food supplies. Loyal citizens moved to his territory, and he had a large family. God's will was clear, and Rehoboam benefited greatly. Yet, the writer of the Chronicles could not explain God's purposes. Readers today still wonder why God allowed the kingdom to stay divided.

The prophet Isaiah reveals the mystery of God's ways: "For My thoughts are not your thoughts, neither are your ways My ways," declares the LORD. "For as the heavens are higher than the earth, so My ways are higher than your ways and My thoughts than your thoughts" (Isaiah 55:8-9). Those who revere God learn not to rely on human understanding. Instead, they obey God's word, even when it opposes earthly values.

#### Passages for Further Study

1 Kings 8:56-61; 2 Chronicles 10:1-11:4; Job 42:1-6; Psalm 115:1-3; Isaiah 40:9-31; 42:1-17; 55:8-13; Romans 8:26-30; Ephesians 1:9-14

### God's Instructions

The common Hebrew word torah is usually translated "law" in most English versions. This translation comes from the Greek word nomos, which often means "law." The Septuagint (the ancient Greek Old Testament) used nomos to translate torah. Yet, torah basically means "teaching," "instruction," or "doctrine."

The term law often makes people think of rules enforced by an outside authority, like a government. It is often considered to be strict and rigid. Yet, the torah of Moses gives instructions including:

- Rules
- Stories (Leviticus 10:1-3)
- Poetry (Deuteronomy 32:1-43)
- Lists of family lines (Exodus 6:14-25)
- Other literary forms

Other words translate as "law" and are part of the instructions given to the Israelites. For example, *khoq*, meaning "statute," refers to a law given by a lawgiver (for example, Leviticus 6:22). It states a general principle, allowing context or courts to interpret how to apply it.

In Leviticus 18:4-5 and 19:37, the Hebrew word *khuqqah* (meaning "decrees") is paired with *mishpatim* (meaning "regulations"). These are case laws. It is impossible to write laws for every situation. A case law refers to a court's previous interpretation of a statute in certain cases. The court's past decisions guide similar cases in the present time.

Law is necessary because there will always be people who need it to restrain them from sinning. "Law" can describe much of the Old Testament Torah. More generally, the Torah teaches God's people about him and what their relationship is to him. In a similar way, teaching doctrine and how to live godly are key parts of the Christian church and its life-giving message to the world (Colossians 3:16).

#### Passages for Further Study

Genesis 26:5; Exodus 16:4; Leviticus 6:9, 14; Deuteronomy 17:8-13, 18-20; 2 Kings 10:30-31; 22:8-20; Job 22:21-23; Psalms 40:8; 78:9-12; Proverbs 6:20-23; 13:14; 28:9; Isaiah 8:20; Colossians 3:16; 2 Timothy 3:14-17

### God's Judgment of His People

The kings of Israel and Judah were very important in the history of the divided kingdom. But the people also

influenced events. They followed their wicked rulers (2 Kings 3:3; 17:22; 21:9, 11, 16). They stopped obeying God (12:3; 14:4; 15:4, 35; 17:9–11; 18:4; 22:17). They took part in the religious practices started by Jeroboam I (10:28–31; 17:21–22). They worshiped at pagan shrines (holy places) (12:3; 14:4; 15:4, 35; 18:4).

During this time, the Scripture sometimes describes God's people positively. The people of Judah celebrated when they removed Queen Athaliah and Joash became king (2 Kings 11:12, 18–20). Sometimes, the people helped choose new kings or followed good leaders (14:21; 23:30; 11:17; 18:36; 23:1–3, 21–23).

God continued to warn his people through his prophets (2 Kings 17:13). Yet, the people of both kingdoms continued to rebel against God (17:14–19, 22). As a result, God judged them as he promised (17:22–23; 21:10–15; 22:17; 23:26–27; 24:20; 25:21). God acted according to the terms of his special agreement (called a covenant) with them (Leviticus 26:27–39).

Yet, he still loved his people and wanted to restore them (see Hosea 11:1–11). God always cared for his people. He saved them from Sennacherib (2 Kings 18:17–19:37). He promised that a small group would thrive again in the land (19:30–31). The good treatment King Jehoiachin received in Babylon probably renewed hope among the repentant people (25:27–30).

God promised to restore his people from exile. He would give them fellowship with him in the land again. He would rule over them through his chosen king, a descendant of David (Jeremiah 23:3–6; see also Isaiah 11; Romans 11:5–36).

#### Passages for Further Study

Leviticus 26:27–39; 2 Kings 17:7–23; 21:9–16; 23:26–27; 24:20–25:21; Psalm 62:12; Proverbs 11:31; Isaiah 3:10–11; Jeremiah 1:16; 17:10; 23:3–6; Ezekiel 7:1–9; 33:18–20; 34:17–24; 39:23–24; Hosea 11:1–11; Amos 3:2; Matthew 25:24–30; Luke 12:47–48; 13:6–9; John 5:45–47; Romans 11:5–36; Colossians 3:23–25; Hebrews 12:25; James 2:12–13; 1 Peter 1:17; Revelation 2:1–3:22

### God's Justice

God is just (Psalm 9:7–8). He hates sin and fairly rewards people and nations based on what they do (Psalm 67:4; Isaiah 1:27; Jeremiah 46:28; Joel 3:1–8; Acts 17:31). God has complete control over the natural world and all nations (Nahum 1:4–6, 8; 1:3, 6–10, 15). The world and its people are powerless when opposing him (Job 41:10–11; Isaiah 40:22–24).

The Lord's justice, known as *mishpat* in Hebrew, is part of his divine order. A world without justice ignores

the creator's plan. Since the creator is just, his rule will also be just and righteous (Deuteronomy 32:4). His Messiah (God's chosen one) will bring about a just world (Isaiah 9:7; 11:2–5; 16:5; 32:1–2). His Spirit will change the world into a place of justice, fairness, and peace (32:15–17). This is good news for the oppressed, whose rights powerful people in society have denied (see 25:4–5).

God's justice may sometimes appear slow (Nahum 1:3). This delay is due to his patience and mercy toward people (Jonah 3–4; 2 Peter 3:9–15). God does not give justice without care. He provides justice with love and intends to bring those who deserve judgment into a relationship with him.

The theme of God's justice is key in the prophets, especially in the book of Isaiah. God wants his people to treat others justly (Micah 6:8; Zechariah 7:9; Isaiah 1:17; 5:7; 58:6–7). He often criticizes the people of Israel for acting unjustly, especially to the poor and needy (for example, Amos 5:11–12; Malachi 3:5; Isaiah 3:12–15; 5:7–8; 10:1–4; 29:21). Many prophets of Israel announce God's judgment on his people for their injustice. They also share prophecies against other oppressive, proud, and unjust nations. God's punishment for these actions is just (see Isaiah 3:9–11; 13:11; 59:18).

The book of Nahum specifically shows God's justice toward Nineveh (1:14; 2:13; 3:4). Nahum's "good news" is that those who trust in God will one day enjoy peace and well-being when evil is finally defeated (Nahum 1:15; see also Isaiah 11:1–9; Zephaniah 3:13). This promise began its fulfillment through the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus Christ (Acts 10:34–43; Romans 10:9–15). Those who trust in the Lord Jesus experience some blessings of salvation now. Yet, they wait for God's final judgment of evil and the complete arrival of his kingdom (see Revelation 20:7–22:5).

All humanity is condemned because of sin before the just and holy God. Yet, God offers grace that we do not deserve. Through Jesus Christ, God placed his judgment against sin on a willing substitute. Jesus' death is a substitute for humanity's death. Jesus' death encourages people to turn away from sin and live by God's righteousness (Romans 6:22–23; 1 Peter 3:18). When God finally establishes his kingdom through Jesus, the world will also be just and righteous (Isaiah 1:26; 28:6; 2 Peter 3:13).

#### Passages for Further Study

Genesis 18:17–19, 25; Exodus 34:6–7; Leviticus 19:15; Deuteronomy 16:18–20; 17:8–13; 32:4; Psalms 9:7–8; 67:4; 89:14; 119:75; Proverbs 21:3; Ecclesiastes 12:14; Isaiah 1:17–28; 5:7; 11:1–9; 16:5; 32:1–2, 16–17; 40:22–24; 61:8; Je-

Jeremiah 46:27–28; Lamentations 3:25–39; Ezekiel 34:15–16; 36:22–36; 37:24–27; Joel 3:1–2; Amos 5:21–24; Jonah 3:1–4:11; Micah 6:6–8; Nahum 1:3–10; 3:4; Zechariah 7:9–10; Matthew 5:6, 10, 20; Luke 1:74–75; Acts 10:34–43; 17:30–31; 2 Peter 3:11–14; Revelation 20:11–15

## God's Love for Israel

The prophet Malachi begins his message to the people of Israel with, “I have loved you,” says the LORD” (Malachi 1:2). God's love for Israel is clear throughout the Old Testament. Malachi tells people to look at history to see God's love and power. This connects his book to the Bible's larger story of salvation.

The writer of Psalm 78, for example, declares God's great acts to future generations, so each one might “put their confidence in God... keeping His commandments” (Psalm 78:2–4, 7). The key event in Old Testament history is the exodus from Egypt (see Psalms 78:12–13; 105:26–38; 106:7–12). This was when God freed the Israelites from slavery in Egypt and led them out of the country. Israel remembered this event every year during the Feast of Passover. They used formal instruction (catechism) to teach the next generation about God's mighty acts (Exodus 12–13). This guaranteed they would always remember his loving actions.

Unfortunately, the people of Israel often abandoned God and broke their covenant (special agreement) with him. Even so, his love for them never fully disappeared (see Hosea 3:1). Their rebellion resulted in God's judgment, leading finally to exile from their land. But even during this disaster, he saved a small group of his people (called a “remnant”) and promised to restore them to the land (Isaiah 65:8–9).

The Old Testament prophets told of a future when God would show his love for Israel by sending:

- a Branch of David (Isaiah 11:1–5);
- a righteous King (Zechariah 9:9–10); and
- a Sun of righteousness (Malachi 4:1–3).

Jesus Christ fulfilled these prophecies. His death created another important event for God's people. Christians commemorate his death with a meal, “the Lord's Supper” (1 Corinthians 11:20–34). This act of redemption showed God's ultimate love for Jews and even non-Jews (gentiles).

### Passages for Further Study

Exodus 12:1–13:16; Psalms 47:4; 78:2–4, 7, 12–13; 98:3; 105:26–27, 37; 106:7–8; Hosea 3:1; 11:1; Malachi 1:2; 1 Corinthians 5:7; 11:20–34; 15:1–4

## God's Name on His Temple

In his prayer of dedication, King Solomon said the temple was the house where God would put his name (2 Chronicles 6:20; compare 6:5–6). God said that a descendant of King David would build “a house for My Name” in Jerusalem (2 Samuel 7:4–17). When God puts his name on a place, it means it belongs to God.

For the people of Israel, the temple stood in the promised land as the place marked by God's name and presence. It was the ultimate symbol of God's relationship with Israel. Solomon prayed that God would remember this relationship and listen to their prayers at the temple.

In many English Bible translations, Yahweh is represented as “LORD” written in all capital letters (see Exodus 3:13–15). Solomon's prayer repeatedly connects the temple with Yahweh's name and with Israel's covenant worship. This shows that the temple became an important center of Israel's faith. The temple was the chosen place where the people kept and remembered God's covenant (the special agreement that God made with the Israelites). This is where the people of Israel called on God's name and acknowledged him in confession and praise.

The fulfillment of God's promise to put his name on his temple is now found in the “living temple,” which is the community of God's people. The apostle Peter urges believers to come to “the living stone, rejected by men but chosen and precious in God's sight, you also, like living stones, are being built into a spiritual house to be a holy priesthood, offering spiritual sacrifices acceptable to God through Jesus Christ” (1 Peter 2:4–5).

Just as God's name was connected to the temple, the center of God's presence and worship in the Old Testament, God's name now rests on the church, God's people, who are the new temple in the New Testament.

### Passages for Further Study

Exodus 3:13–15; 2 Samuel 7:12–13; 2 Chronicles 6:3–42; Psalm 23:3; 1 Peter 2:4–5

## God's New Covenant

A covenant is a promise or agreement between two groups or people that usually includes responsibilities for each side. God made a covenant with the people of Israel through Moses and the giving of the law (Exodus 19–24). Later, God promised to establish a new covenant with his people (Jeremiah 31:31–34). Jesus started this new covenant (see Luke 22:19–20). He

removes “the veil” of the old covenant (2 Corinthians 3:14). The apostle Paul uses the creation story from Genesis 1–2 to explain that the God of creation is also the God of “a new creation” (2 Corinthians 4:4–6; 5:17). God now reveals himself in Jesus Christ, who brings God close to us.

In the new covenant, God, the Father of our Lord Jesus the Christ, is also our Father because he has spiritually adopted us (2 Corinthians 1:3; Galatians 3:26–4:7). He is the faithful God whose Old Testament promises come true in Christ (2 Corinthians 1:18–22). He is the author of reconciliation. Christ became the way God reconciled the sinful world with himself (5:18–21). Jesus Christ became a human being (see 8:9). He released God's saving power and righteousness to restore the relationship between God and the world.

Under the new covenant, God sends his Spirit to live among his people. The Spirit gives Christians life, freedom, and the ability to obey Christ (3:6, 17–18). The Spirit unites us to Christ and guarantees our complete salvation in the resurrection (1:22; 5:1–5). This is when Christians' mortal bodies will change into glorified bodies (1 Corinthians 15:42–57). Paul fully explains this hope in 2 Corinthians 5:1–10. This will be the final result of the new covenant that God has made with his people.

#### Passages for Further Study

Genesis 9:1–17; 12:1–9; 15:1–21; Exodus 19:3–6; 2 Samuel 7:5–16; 1 Chronicles 10:13–14; Isaiah 59:20–21; 65:17–25; Jeremiah 2:1–3:10; 31:31–34; Matthew 26:27–29; Luke 22:20; 1 Corinthians 11:23–32; 2 Corinthians 3:4–18; 4:4–6; Hebrews 8:6–13; 9:11–28; 10:1–25; 12:18–24

### God's Plan to Restore

One of the best-known verses in the book of 2 Chronicles explains God's plan for Israel: “And if My people who are called by My name humble themselves and pray and seek My face and turn from their wicked ways, then I will hear from heaven, forgive their sin, and heal their land” (2 Chronicles 7:14). This verse shows the how the writer of the Chronicles views the way God works with his people. Some call this idea a “theology of immediate retribution.” This means that each person experiences the results of their actions during their lifetime.

The words humble, pray, turn, seek, and heal often appear in the Chronicles. The writer of Chronicles shows how these actions affected the kings of Judah. One clear example is the celebration of Passover during King Hezekiah's rule. In the first month of his rule, Hezekiah began restoring the temple (2 Chronicles

29:3). He invited all of Israel, including the northern kingdom, to the Passover feast in Jerusalem (30:1).

Hezekiah's messengers urged the people to “return to the LORD” (2 Chronicles 30:6). Many from the north humbled themselves and came to Jerusalem (30:11). So many people came that the Judeans could not accommodate them. Those from the north did not ceremonially prepare themselves to observe the Passover.

Hezekiah prayed for the people as they decided to seek the Lord (2 Chronicles 30:18–19). The Lord healed the people, allowing everyone to participate (30:20). The festival was so successful that they extended it for another seven days (30:23). Hezekiah followed the principles Solomon had stated in his prayer. King Manasseh is another example of God's redemption at work (33:11–23).

Israelites who knew the themes of Chronicles would understand the message of John the Baptist. He called for repentance and healing (Matthew 3:5–12). If you do not repent, you will experience judgment. Yet, God will redeem those willing to humble themselves before him.

#### Passages for Further Study

2 Chronicles 7:13–15; 12:5–12; 14:1–7; 15:1–19; 25:14–28; 26:5, 16; 29:3–31:21; 32:24–26; 33:10–17; 34:3–33; Matthew 3:5–12; Romans 5:8–11, 19–21

### God's Presence in the Psalms

The writers of Scripture often express the desire to experience God's presence. In this close experience, God's goodness and love are all people need (see Psalm 21:6). In a similar way, when God is absent, it causes distress and harm.

The poets of Israel often spoke as if God has a “face” to show his presence or absence. They sought his “face” (Psalms 4:6; 105:4). When God caused “His face to shine” or turned toward his people, they felt his presence. This came through blessings, provision, and protection (67:1; 80:3–19).

When God hid his “face,” it represented divine abandonment (Psalms 13:1; 27:9; 44:24; 69:17; 88:14; 89:46; 102:2; 104:29; 143:7). It was as if God did not see or hear them (10:11; 42:3). God's absence causes fear, shame, and chaos, and could even lead to death (30:7; 44:24; 104:29).

The psalmists (the people who wrote the psalms) prayed for God's presence when they wanted a change in situation (Psalms 31:15–16; 67:1; 69:17; 80:3, 7, 19). They recognized that his presence helped them (44:3). Faithful people desire to be in God's presence (11:7;

16:9–11; 17:15). His presence alone fulfills their deepest desires (17:15). It brings them lasting joy (37:4; 43:4; 73:25). Everything about God brings them joy.

People experience God's favor and goodness through his presence (Psalm 23:6). Blessings, abundant crops, and prosperity indicate his presence (21:3; 65:11; 68:10; 85:12; 106:5; 128:2). God's goodness closely connects to the temple, where his presence is especially obvious (65:4). His presence brings health and life to his people and provides their needs (107:9). For the psalmists, God's presence was necessary for living well and thriving.

#### Passages for Further Study

Psalms 4:6; 13:1; 21:6; 24:3–6; 27:9; 44:3, 24; 67:1; 69:17; 88:14; 89:46; 102:2; 104:29; 143:7

### God's Promised Kingdom

God promised that his kingdom would come through King David (1 Chronicles 17:4–14). During his rule, David prepared for building the temple, which would be the center of God's kingdom (28:11–19). He urged Israel's leaders to “keep and seek out all the commandments of the LORD” (28:8–10). He encouraged the community of Israel to be strong and brave in trusting God to provide (28:20–21).

The writer of the Chronicles used King David's words to encourage the people of Judea after the Israelite exile. He urged them to keep trusting that God would restore the kingdom. He wanted them to know that God's promise to David, later confirmed to King Solomon, was also true for them.

After the exile, Judah was no longer an independent kingdom ruled by David's family. Instead, Judea was a small area with limited freedom under the control of a Persian governor. Still, the people of Judea could receive God's blessings, just like during the times of kings Hezekiah and Josiah. The writer of the Chronicles did not know exactly how God's promise to David would come true. Yet, he fully trusted in God's power, sovereign control, and justice. He believed that God would keep his promise and that his kingdom would eventually rule over all.

After the time of the writer of the Chronicles, the people became discouraged. The Greeks took control of Israel from the Persians. The Greek rulers were not friendly to the Jewish people and their beliefs. One Greek ruler, Antiochus IV (who called himself “Epiphanes”), was especially cruel during his rule from 175 to 163 BC. He tried very hard to destroy the Jewish faith and way of life. The prophet Daniel had predicted this would happen (Daniel 11:21–39).

The priestly family of the Maccabees resisted Antiochus, restored the temple, and preserved Judea's identity. Yet, the community became disunited under the Maccabees' successors. Israel divided into groups like the Pharisees, Sadducees, and Essenes. Eventually, the Romans controlled them. When Jesus was born, Roman governors ruled Israel.

God's promises to David came true in an unexpected way. Jesus was the anointed king (the Christ or Messiah) from David's line. He established his Kingdom not by defeating the Romans in battle but by defeating the power of sin and death. His kingdom expands through his followers, and hell's powers will never conquer it. Ultimately, his kingdom will fully triumph over evil, and he will rule as king forever (see Revelation 19:11–20:15).

#### Passages for Further Study

1 Chronicles 17:9–14; 28:1–21; Isaiah 2:1–4; 60:1–22; 65:17–25; Ezekiel 37:21–28; Daniel 2:31–45; 7:1–28; Micah 4:1–5; Zechariah 9:9–10; 14:1–21; Matthew 4:17; 6:33; 13:11–50; 16:16–19; 18:3–4, 23–35; 19:14, 23–30; 20:1–16; 22:2–14; 25:1–46; Luke 1:30–33; Ephesians 5:5; Revelation 19:1–21:27

### God's Rule and Power Over All Nations

In ancient times, most people thought each nation had its own god or gods. For example, the king of Aram thought Israel's gods were only powerful in the hills (1 Kings 20:23). When the judge Jephthah talked about the false god Chemosh giving land to the Ammonites, he was showing he still thought like people who worshiped many gods (Judges 11:24).

In contrast, the prophet Amos knew that God alone brought the Philistines from Crete and the Arameans from Kir (Amos 9:7). God created the entire universe, not just Israel (4:13; 5:8). So, he had the right to demand that nations act with justice and mercy (1:3–2:3).

A common false belief (heresy) among the people of Judah and Israel was that despite their sins, God would eventually support them because of his covenant with them (see Jeremiah 7:4; Amos 3:1–2; 9:10). They mistakenly believed that the “day of the Lord” meant automatic rescue for them and destruction for their enemies. Amos directly challenged this false sense of privilege (9:7; see also 5:18–20). The day of the Lord would not forgive sinful Israel. Instead, God would use it to punish them.

Israel's privileged position among nations made them more responsible. While nearby nations experienced punishment for severe sins, God punished Israel for all

their sins (Amos 3:2). The New Testament expands on this idea: "Everyone who has been given much" has greater responsibility (Luke 12:48; James 3:1).

#### Passages for Further Study

Exodus 15:18; Deuteronomy 32:8; 1 Chronicles 29:11-12; 2 Chronicles 20:6; Psalms 2:1-12; 7:6-8; 10:16; 22:28; 47:2; 83:18; 93:1-5; 103:19; Daniel 2:20-21, 47; 4:34-37; Amos 9:7; Matthew 28:18-20; Acts 17:24-26; 1 Timothy 1:17; 6:15; Revelation 15:3-4; 17:14; 19:16

### God's Sabbath Rest

The idea of God's Sabbath rest (as described in Hebrews 4:1-11) has been difficult for many scholars to understand. It includes ideas from the Old Testament, like the promised land as a place to rest from slavery and wandering. It also speaks of the Sabbath day as a weekly day of rest. In Hebrews 3:7-19, the author explains Psalm 95:7-11. He uses the Israelite wilderness wanderers as an example of those who did not enter God's rest because they disobeyed.

What is the "rest" they failed to enter, which still remains for God's people (Hebrews 4:1-3)? The author of Hebrews meant more than just the physical land of Canaan as the place of "Sabbath rest" (4:8-9). Genesis 2:2 describes God's rest as something prepared "since the foundation of the world" (Hebrews 4:3-4). God's rest involves stopping one's own work, just as God did (4:10). Those who "hear His voice," do not harden their hearts, and believe the good news about Jesus can "enter that rest" (4:1-3, 7).

The Old Testament calls the Day of Atonement "a Sabbath of complete rest" (Leviticus 16:29-31). On that day, people stopped all their work. In the new covenant, Jesus, our Great High Priest, offered a one-time sacrifice that did "away with sin" (9:7-28). He was the final atoning sacrifice, making peace between God and people. Jesus offers people spiritual rest. They can enter this rest by trusting and obeying this good news.

God's rest through Jesus has two aspects:

1. Those who follow Jesus stop trying to earn God's acceptance through their own efforts. They trust in Jesus' completed work (Ephesians 2:8-9). They enjoy peace with God (John 14:27; Acts 10:36; Romans 5:1; 2 Corinthians 5:19-21).
2. They anticipate eternal rest and joy in God's presence (Isaiah 26:19; Revelation 14:13). Jesus Christ gives complete and perfect rest (Matthew 11:28-30).

#### Passages for Further Study

Genesis 2:1-3; Exodus 16:21-29; 20:8-11; 31:13-16; Leviticus 16:29-31; Isaiah 52:7; 54:13-14; 56:2, 4; 57:2, 21;

58:13; Ezekiel 20:20; Matthew 11:28-30; Mark 2:23-28; Luke 8:48; John 14:27; Acts 10:36; Romans 5:1; 15:13; 2 Corinthians 5:19-21; Ephesians 2:17; Colossians 1:20; 2:16; 3:15; Hebrews 4:1-11; 2 Peter 1:2

### God's Servant

In Isaiah 40-66, God's servant is very important and appears often. The servant announces a new order of justice and righteousness to the world (42:3-4). He prepares the world for God's arrival (52:7).

Who is the Lord's servant? Isaiah identifies the servant as "Israel," who acts as God's witness and a "light" to other nations (Isaiah 41:8; 44:1-2; 43:10). Yet, the nation of Israel could not fully complete this mission because it was spiritually deaf and blind, and needed God's forgiveness (42:19; 44:21-22). Israel failed repeatedly.

In contrast, God's servant is faithful and waits for redemption (see Isaiah 61:1-3; 62:1-5). The servant represents the godly people in Israel. The servant is God's faithful witness to humanity and opposes idolatrous practices of pagan religion.

The prophet Isaiah describes the servant as obedient and suffering. Jesus Christ fulfilled the idea of the "suffering servant." He was an Israelite who was perfectly faithful and suffered for others. Through his suffering, God's blessings reached many, including other nations (see Acts 26:22-23).

United with Christ, the apostles shared God's message as God's servants with both Jews and gentiles (Acts 13:47; 26:14-18). All who trust in Jesus share the mission of the "servant." They act as God's servants in the world (for example, Colossians 1:7; 4:12; 1 Timothy 4:6; 2 Timothy 2:24).

#### Passages for Further Study

Leviticus 25:42, 55; 1 Kings 11:36; 2 Kings 9:7; Psalms 89:20-29; 113:1; Isaiah 41:8-10; 42:1-4, 19-20; 43:10; 44:1-5, 21-22; 49:1-7; 52:7, 13-53:12; 61:1-3; Jeremiah 30:10; 33:20-22, 26; 46:27-28; Ezekiel 28:25; 34:23-24; 37:24-25; Zechariah 3:8; Matthew 12:15-21; Acts 2:18; 2 Timothy 2:24

### God's Unified Plan of Salvation

God reveals his plan for salvation throughout Scripture. It is a key theme in the letter to the Romans. In Romans 3:21, the apostle Paul emphasizes two important points about being "made right" with God through Jesus Christ:

1. It does not rely on following Old Testament laws and regulations.

2. It was “attested by the Law and the Prophets” (Romans 3:21; see also 1:2).

God always intended to save the world through Jesus. The Old Testament prepared people for this important moment in salvation history. Paul often returns to this theme of scriptural continuity (the idea that the message and actions of God in the Bible are consistent and connected throughout all of Scripture). This is especially true of Romans 9–11. There, Paul explains how God's relationship with Israel fits into this ongoing plan.

Paul wants to help us understand the changes in God's single plan for salvation. This plan unfolds in parts. Now that the final part in Christ has arrived, the earlier part has ended. The law of Moses no longer rules God's people. Paul often stresses that our new relationship with God is separate from the law of Moses (see 6:14; 7:4–6; 10:4).

A similar idea appears in John 1:17 and Hebrews 10:1. Paul's focus in Romans on God's plan helps us understand the Bible's story in a way that respects all parts of this plan.

#### Passages for Further Study

Matthew 1:21–23; Luke 1:46–55, 67–79; Acts 4:10–12; 10:34–43; 13:23–41; Romans 1:3–5, 16–17; 3:21–26; 5:6–11; 8:1–4; 10:5–13; 11:26–27; 1 Corinthians 15:1–4; Galatians 2:14–21; 3:5–14; Ephesians 1:3–14; Colossians 1:15–22; 1 Timothy 2:3–6; 2 Timothy 1:9–10; Hebrews 9:27–28

### God's Uniqueness

As Creator, God is separate from what he has made. God is not part of nature. He created nature and governs it. He has always existed as the living God. God planned how everything in the universe would work according to his rules. He gave life to every living thing. Because he is God, he is everywhere at all times and knows everything. He is the living God who shows perfect love, holiness, justice, and power.

The people who lived in lands near Israel worshiped many different gods. They often made these gods to look like things in nature, such as the sun, moon, or storms. But these gods were not real. They were just lifeless statues that could not move or do anything (see Jeremiah 10:1–5). These false gods could not communicate with people or have any relationship with them. They had no power at all, not even enough to move themselves.

Sadly, the people of Israel often copied their neighbors and started worshiping these false gods too. When this happened, God sent prophets (people who spoke

God's messages) to remind the Israelites that the true God was completely different from these lifeless statues. The prophets taught that there was only one real God who had true power.

Unlike lifeless idols, the one, true, living God connects personally with humans, even though he is different. He involves himself in people's lives and shows his will so each person can understand his desires and respond to him. The Lord, who created everything, surprisingly seeks a personal relationship with his people.

#### Passages for Further Study

Genesis 1:1–2:4; Exodus 15:11; 20:2–6; Deuteronomy 4:32–39; 33:26; Job 38:1–41:34; Psalms 86:8; 115:4–7; 139:1–18; Isaiah 42:8; 44:9–20; Jeremiah 10:1–16; 14:22; Amos 4:13; 5:8–9; Revelation 15:3–4

### God's Word

A basic truth of Scripture is that God has spoken. The author of the letter to the Hebrews, like other Jewish preachers of the time, presents the Old Testament as words from God. He often starts passages with “God says...” or similar phrases. God may speak a promise or a warning (Hebrews 6:13–14; 3:11; 4:11–12). He may tell us about himself or his son or reveal his will (see 1:5–12; see 8:7–13; 10:5–7). God's word created the universe and still controls it (Genesis 1:3–28; Hebrews 1:3; 11:3).

In the past, God's word came mainly through angels or prophets. Now, it comes mainly through Jesus, God's son (Hebrews 1:1–4; 2:3–4; compare John 1:1–14). People must hear, listen to, obey, and believe this word as a source of hope.

Through his word, God starts a relationship with us. He wants us to listen and respond with faith (see Genesis 15:6; John 1:12). His word is powerful and purposeful, offering deep hope because God keeps his promises (Hebrews 6:13–20).

#### Passages for Further Study

Genesis 1:3–28; Deuteronomy 8:3; Psalms 12:6; 19:8; 119:11, 89, 105; Isaiah 40:8; Jeremiah 15:16; 23:29; 36:2; Matthew 5:18; 7:24; John 1:1–14; 5:24; 2 Timothy 3:16; Hebrews 1:1–4; 4:12; 6:13–20; 11:3; 1 Peter 1:25; 2 Peter 1:19–21

### God's Word at the Center

After God told Moses the law at Mount Sinai, God wrote it in stone (Exodus 34:1). He intended the Israelites to teach it to their children (Deuteronomy 6:7). People attached it to their hands and foreheads,

They even wrote it on the doorposts of their homes to remind them of God's words (Deuteronomy 6:8-9).

Every seven years, the priests read God's instructions to the people to help them remember to revere God (Deuteronomy 31:9-13). Success came from studying and obeying God's word (Joshua 1:7-8; Psalms 1:2; 119:15). Obedience was more important than offering sacrifices (1 Samuel 15:22).

When God's people ignore the Scriptures and lose sight of his truth, they often stop living how he wants. During King Josiah's time, even the priests had lost and forgotten the book of the law. When they found it in the temple, the young king read it and tore his clothing in grief. He realized the nation had abandoned the covenant (2 Kings 22:8-13).

In the fall of 445 BC, Nehemiah managed the completion of the rebuilding of Jerusalem's wall. Five days later, on the first day of the seventh month, the settlers in Judah gathered to celebrate the Feast of Trumpets. During and after the feast, the priest and scribe Ezra read from the law God gave Moses.

As the people listened, they mourned and wept because they realized they had not obeyed God's law. They confessed their sins, studied God's word to learn what he required, and obeyed what they learned. The book of the law of Moses transformed their lives and behavior.

These events dramatically remind us that God's word is central to the lives of his people. The Scriptures are an essential guide for life and death (Genesis 2:16-17). God's promises always come true (for example, 17:15-21; 18:10-14).

God's word is perfect. It can restore, make people wise, and bring joy (Psalm 19:7-9). Godly people love the Scriptures (119:97). It lights their paths and helps them avoid sin (119:105, 9). God's word achieves its purpose (Isaiah 55:11). It remains forever (Matthew 5:17-19; 24:35; 2 Timothy 3:14-17).

#### Passages for Further Study

Exodus 24:7; 34:1; Deuteronomy 4:2; 6:4-9; 31:9-13; Joshua 1:7-8; 1 Samuel 15:22; Nehemiah 8:1-10:39; 13:1-3; Psalms 1:2-3; 19:7-9; 119:9, 15, 97, 105; Isaiah 55:10-11; Matthew 5:17-19; 13:3-23; 24:35; 2 Timothy 3:14-17

## The Good News Message

The apostles shared the good news about Jesus (or "gospel") in a specific order, with these parts:

1. The Old Testament promises came true through Jesus Christ's life, death, and resurrection.

2. God has lifted up Jesus by raising him from the dead to be the leader of the new people of God as the Messiah chosen by God.
3. The apostles witnessed God's work in Jesus Christ. They saw his public ministry and resurrection (Acts 2:32; 3:15; 4:33; 5:30-32; 13:30-31). They served as his chosen messengers (10:39-43).
4. The right response to this good news is to repent (turn away from sin) and trust in Jesus (Acts 2:38; 3:19; 13:39, 48; 17:30; 20:21; 26:20).
5. God promises to give the Holy Spirit to those who accept God's forgiveness and salvation from sin through Jesus Christ.

The apostles often shared this basic message with both Jews and non-Jews (called gentiles) across the Mediterranean region (see Acts 1:8; 9:15). You can find it in the speeches of Peter and Philip in 2:14-41; 3:12-26; 4:8-12; 5:29-32; 8:4-13, 26-40; and 10:34-43. Paul's preaching also includes these themes (for example, Acts 13:16-49; 1 Corinthians 15:1-11).

This powerful message of God's saving grace changes people's wills and minds to obey him. Receiving this message is the first step towards salvation. God calls everyone to repent from sin and trust in the saving power of Jesus (Acts 4:12; 13:38; 16:30-31). Through Jesus, God continues to make everyone right with him who continues to trust in him (13:39).

#### Passages for Further Study

Matthew 4:23-24; 24:14; Mark 1:1, 14-15; Luke 4:18-21; Acts 2:14-40; 3:12-26; 8:25-40; Acts 10:34-43; 13:16-41; 16:31; 17:16-31; 20:21; Romans 1:1-5, 15-17; 10:15-17; 16:25-27; 1 Corinthians 1:18; 15:3-8; 2 Corinthians 4:3-7; Ephesians 1:13; 2:4-18; 2 Thessalonians 2:13-14; 2 Timothy 1:9-10; 2:8-13; Hebrews 4:1-16; 1 Peter 1:3-12; Revelation 14:6-7

## The Grace of God

Grace is an important word in the Bible. It shows God's kindness and favor. It is often related to how he saves those who do not deserve it. The New Testament emphasizes that grace came through Jesus Christ (John 1:14-17). This does not mean God's grace was absent in the Old Testament. Instead, God's grace toward humanity achieved its goal through his Son.

According to the book of Acts, the Jewish community was the first to experience God's great favor (see Acts 11:19-21; 13:43-49). Later, it became obvious that God's grace through Jesus Christ also extends to non-Jewish people (gentiles) (Acts 15:8-9; Ephesians 2:11-18; Titus 2:11). Miraculous signs and wonders confirmed God's grace at work among the gentiles (Acts 14:3).

The apostle Paul shared the good news (the gospel) about God's wonderful grace (Acts 20:24). He did not try to prove God's grace. He assumed it as true when sharing the good news (see, for example, Romans 3:24; 5:15–21). Paul made it plain that we do not earn our salvation.

God acts only through his grace (Romans 4:4–5; Ephesians 2:4–9). People cannot do good works to earn us favor with God. If they did, God would have to reward them like a worker earns a wage (see Romans 11:5–6).

God's grace affects Christians throughout their lives, not just at conversion. The letter of 2 Peter ends with a command for Christians to "grow in the grace" of "Jesus Christ" (2 Peter 3:18). Paul "urged them to continue in the grace of God" as they remained faithful to their Lord (Acts 13:43).

When Paul left the leaders of the church at Ephesus, he entrusted them "to God and to the word of His grace." This was a divine message that could strengthen and support them (Acts 20:32; see 15:40). God's grace is central to the Christian message and experience, from start to finish. It is no surprise that grace is a common theme in the writings of Jesus' early followers.

#### Passages for Further Study

Exodus 34:5–7; Numbers 6:22–27; Ezra 9:8; Psalms 30:5; 31:16; Psalm 84:11; Isaiah 60:10; 61:1–3; Hosea 14:1–9; Luke 4:18–19; Acts 15:11; 20:24; Romans 5:15–17, 20–21; 12:6; 2 Corinthians 6:1; 8:9; 12:9; Galatians 2:21; 4:10; 5:3–6; Ephesians 1:3–8; 2:4–10; 2 Timothy 1:9; 2:1; Titus 2:11; 3:7; Hebrews 2:9; 4:16; 13:9; James 4:6; 1 Peter 5:5–6, 12; 2 Peter 3:17–18

## The Growth of the Church

The book of Acts describes the church's growth after the day of Pentecost. Initially, the church increased in numbers. After Jesus' ascension to heaven, only 120 Christians attended the first prayer meeting to seek divine guidance (Acts 1:12–15). After the Holy Spirit's powerful arrival on Pentecost, the number of Christians increased to about 3,000 (2:41). Many more accepted Peter and John's preaching of the good news about Jesus (the gospel), increasing the number to about 5,000 (4:4). The church continued to increase (5:14; 6:1; 9:31; 21:20).

There is also plain evidence of geographical spread (see Acts 1:8; 9:15). The church was not only in Jerusalem. The gospel message spread to Lydda, Sharon, and Joppa on the Mediterranean coast (9:32–43). The message of salvation in Christ also expanded from its Jewish base into Samaria (8:4–12).

Then it spread into Phoenicia, Cyprus, and Antioch (11:19–26). As Peter declared to the household of the Roman centurion Cornelius, "God does not show favoritism" (10:34). The message of "the gospel of peace through Jesus Christ" is for everyone (10:36).

As the Christian faith increased in numbers and spread geographically, Christian communities also experienced deeper spiritual growth. Acts 2:42–47 shows this development in the church's inner life. It emphasizes united prayer during crises, generous sharing, courage in persecution, and bold witnessing (4:23–31, 32–37; 5:27–33, 40–42; 16:19–25). The preaching of the deacon and evangelist Philip, the deacon Stephen's manner of dying, and the behavior of the apostles Paul and Silas in prison showed great spiritual maturity (7:59–60; 8:4–40; 16:19–25).

Church leaders encouraged Christians, strengthened their faith, and helped them endure persecution (14:22; 15:32, 41; 18:23; see 2 Timothy 1:8; 2:1–9; 3:12). They lived by the standards they set for others (1 Corinthians 4:16, 20; Philippians 4:9; 1 Thessalonians 1:5–8; 2 Thessalonians 3:9). The church's careful inclusion of non-Jewish people (gentiles) caused important spiritual and numerical growth. "So the churches were strengthened in the faith and grew daily in numbers" (Acts 16:5).

#### Passages for Further Study

Acts 1:8, 13–15; 2:41–47; 4:4, 23–37; 5:14, 27–33, 40–42; 6:1; 7:59; 8:4–40; 9:15, 31, 35, 42; 10:34, 36; 11:19–26; 14:22; 15:32, 41; 16:5, 19–25; 18:23; 21:20; 1 Corinthians 4:16, 20; Philippians 4:9; 1 Thessalonians 1:5–8; 2 Thessalonians 3:9; 2 Timothy 1:8; 2:1–9; 3:12